

# BATTLE FOR THE SKIES

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WORLD WAR II WAS MOSTLY FOUGHT with aircraft that were at least on the drawing board before the war began. Although jet aircraft and missiles played a part in the later stages, the main technical developments of the war years centered on radar and other electronic devices. The real novelty was the sheer scale of the production and deployment of aircraft, with more than a thousand bombers sometimes sent on a single mission. Aircraft played a vital role in army operations, providing ground troops with mobility, supplies, and supporting fire. In the Pacific, naval war became a long-distance battle between aircraft carriers. But the most spectacular use of aircraft was in strategic bombing. Efforts to destroy the enemy's productive capacity and undermine the will to fight culminated in the dropping of the atomic bombs on Japan, which ushered in a new era of warfare.



## DAYLIGHT BOMBER

*A Heinkel He 111 flies over London's Docklands on September 7, 1940, the day of the Luftwaffe's first deliberate bombing raid on the British capital. The bombing of cities from the air was to mount in intensity as the war progressed.*